

## TEACHING &amp; RESEARCH DESIGN

## SCENARIO 2 - GLOBAL TEAM, SHIFTING REQUIREMENTS

## THE STORY

LearnLoop is a startup that just raised 3.2M EUR to build an AI-powered adaptive learning platform for universities. 12 people, three cities, very different skill sets:

(1) Amsterdam (UTC+1) – 4 people:

Product managers, UX designers, 1 frontend developer

Strength: user research, product vision, GDPR knowledge

Weakness: no ML or backend expertise

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## TASK 1 – ANALYSE

| Scrum Element          | Still works?          | Why / Why not?                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2-week sprints         | Partially             | Two-week sprints still provide structure and regular checkpoints. However, the severe time-zone differences and constantly changing customer requirements make it difficult to complete work without interruptions and carry-over tasks.                              |
| Definition of Done     | Needs adjustment      | A traditional Definition of Done assumes requirements are clear. Here, legal approval (FERPA), architecture feasibility, LMS integration, and explainability requirements mean "done" must include compliance checks, technical validation, and cross-team agreement. |
| Backlog prioritization | Currently not working | Austin gathers requirements weekly, but there is no formal process to transfer them into the backlog. Bangalore is developing features before requirements are finalized, causing misalignment.                                                                       |
| Sprint Review Demo     | Still works           | Reviews are valuable because stakeholders disagree on priorities. Demonstrating working increments helps clarify expectations and gather feedback early. However, the right stakeholders (IT,                                                                         |

| Scrum Element     | Still works?       | Why / Why not?                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-------------------|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                   |                    | professors, students, legal) must participate.                                                                                                                                                             |
| Velocity tracking | Limited usefulness | Velocity assumes stable teams and relatively stable work. Frequent requirement changes, legal blockers, and cross-site dependencies distort velocity measurements, making them unreliable for forecasting. |

## TASK 2 – DECIDE

### SITUATION A – WHOSE DESIGN WINS?

#### a. Which option do you choose?

Choice: Option 3

Ship the MVP with the weaker UX, then redesign after the pilot customer has seen it.

#### Justification

- The startup has a fixed **9-month MVP deadline** tied to its pilot customer.
- A three-month architectural redesign significantly threatens delivery.
- The pilot is intended to validate assumptions. Real users may reveal that the "ideal" UX is not essential.
- Delivering a functional product is more valuable than delivering a perfect interface too late.
- The redesign can later be guided by actual pilot feedback rather than assumptions.

#### b. Who has authority to make this call?

The **Product Owner** should make the final decision because it is fundamentally a trade-off between:

- customer value,
- delivery timelines,
- and technical constraints.

The decision should be informed by:

- Amsterdam's UX perspective,
- Bangalore's technical assessment,
- Austin's customer knowledge.

If Amsterdam and Bangalore cannot agree, the Product Owner decides after consulting the stakeholders. If no Product Owner exists, the CEO must temporarily assume that responsibility.

## **SITUATION B – THE ONLY MEETING SLOT**

### **a. Which item do you drop?**

#### **Drop Item 2: Reviewing the six new requirements.**

Use the live meeting for:

1. Finalising the data model.
2. Resolving the architecture conflict.

#### **Justification**

The first two issues are blocking active development:

- Bangalore cannot proceed without the data model.
- The architecture disagreement has already delayed work for two weeks.

The six new requirements are important, but they do not immediately stop development.

### **b. How do you handle it differently?**

Use an **asynchronous decision process**:

- Austin documents the six requirements in the backlog with context and customer impact.
- Amsterdam reviews and prioritises them asynchronously.
- Questions are clarified through written comments or recorded videos.
- Final prioritisation is completed before Austin's Friday customer call.

This prevents the entire team from being blocked by limited overlap time.

## SITUATION C – THE LEGAL BLOCKER

### a. Which option do you choose?

#### Choice: Option 3

Redirect Bangalore to another part of the product while FERPA issues are resolved.

#### Justification

Option 1 wastes 6–8 weeks of highly specialised engineering capacity.

Option 2 allows progress but risks extensive rework if real student data differs substantially from assumptions.

Option 3:

- keeps the team productive,
- advances other critical MVP capabilities such as LMS integration,
- reduces dependency risk,
- avoids investing heavily in potentially invalid assumptions.

Although context switching has costs, they are smaller than the risks associated with waiting or building blindly.

### b. How do you communicate this decision?

I would explain:

"The pause is not due to your work quality or a change in priorities. FERPA approval is an external dependency outside the team's control. To protect the MVP timeline, we're temporarily shifting your expertise toward LMS integration and other high-priority technical work. Once legal clearance arrives, we'll resume recommendation engine development with greater confidence that we're building on compliant foundations."

I would also provide:

- a clear expected review date,
- updated sprint goals,
- and reassurance that recommendation capabilities remain part of the MVP roadmap.

## TASK 3 – REFLECT

### a. Which situation revealed the biggest structural weakness?

Situation B exposed the biggest weakness: **the absence of a structured cross-functional decision-making process across time zones**. Critical information depends on a single weekly meeting, creating bottlenecks and delays.

### b. What needs to change?

LearnLoop needs stronger product governance, including:

- a clearly empowered Product Owner,
- a transparent backlog management process,
- documented asynchronous workflows,
- and representatives from each location participating continuously in discovery and planning.

This would reduce dependence on scarce synchronous meetings.

## AI ANALYSIS

### a. Did the AI make a valid counterargument?

One strong counterargument concerns Situation A. The AI could argue that choosing the weaker UX may damage the pilot so much that universities lose confidence in the product, making the MVP effectively fail despite being delivered on time. This highlights that meeting deadlines is not enough if the user experience undermines adoption.

However, given the fixed nine-month deadline and startup constraints, a three-month redesign remained too risky.

### b. Would you change any of your choices?

I would **keep Situations B and C unchanged** because they minimise blockers and preserve productivity.

For Situation A, I would still choose Option 3, but I would mitigate the weaker UX by identifying the most critical user interactions and improving those within the existing architecture. This balances delivery pressure with user satisfaction.

